

Rocket Scientists' Guide to Religion

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Version .060 / Draft

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Introduction

This is a book about religion. It is a book written to help you understand exactly what religion is and, just as important, what it isn't. It asks the question, "What is religion?" This question matters because, whether you like it or not, religion, whatever that might be, has been, and continues to be, a central part of human society since its inception, and probably before. My favourite theorist on the subject of religion, Ninian Smart, concurs. He says that "throughout history and beyond in the dark recesses of the human race's earliest cultures, religion has been a vital and pervasive feature of human life."¹ He's right, although I might change the word "feature" to "force" because religion is definitely a powerful force, for great good and terrible evil—a Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde sort of affair.

As a powerful force for good, it motivates people to extraordinary acts of generosity and morality. Arthur Brooks, in his large-scale study of charitable behaviour in America, found that "religious people are far more charitable than nonreligious people." He concluded that, "in years of research, I have never found a measurable way in which secularists are more charitable than religious people."² He isn't alone in this finding. Study after study finds that religious participation is the single strongest predictor of charitable giving and volunteering,³ in any religion. Sikhs have the *langar*, a free community kitchen that is part of every Sikh gurdwara (temple). These kitchens serve anyone regardless of religion, caste, or status. Major gurdwaras serve tens of thousands of meals daily, and are run entirely by volunteers (*sevadars*). The largest langar in the world, at the Golden Temple in Amritsar, feeds between 50,000 and 100,000 people a day.⁴ Hindu organizations have built and run charitable healthcare for well over a century. The infrastructure of care we now take for granted: the hospital itself has its origins in religious institutions.⁵ Today the Catholic Church alone manages, by their own (likely inflated) estimates,⁶ roughly a quarter of

1 Ninian Smart, *The Religious Experience*, 5th ed. (Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice Hall, 1996).

2 Arthur C. Brooks, *Who Really Cares: The Surprising Truth About Compassionate Conservatism* (New York: Basic Books, 2006).

3 Robert D. Putnam and David E. Campbell, *American Grace: How Religion Divides and Unites Us* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2010).

4 "About Golden Temple Langar: World's Largest Free Kitchen Feeds over 50,000 People Everyday Here!" (Times of India, 2023), <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/travel/destinations/about-golden-temple-langar-worlds-largest-free-kitchen-feeds-over-50000-people-everyday-here/articleshow/105558743.cms>.

5 Guenter B. Risse, *Mending Bodies, Saving Souls: A History of Hospitals* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999).

6 Jill Olivier and Quentin Wodon, "Faith-Inspired Health Care Provision in Ghana: Market Share, Reach to the Poor, and Performance," *Review of Faith & International Affairs* 12, no. 1 (2014): 84–96.

the world's healthcare facilities — around 117,000 hospitals, clinics, and homes for the sick.⁷ The Uganda Muslim Medical Bureau runs 63 rural facilities in Uganda.⁸ At the highest level, religion has been the driving force behind some of humanity's most important moral advances. The abolition of the slave trade in Britain was spearheaded by the evangelical William Wilberforce. The American civil rights movement was led by the Reverend Martin Luther King Jr.⁹

But, to borrow a phrase from *Star Wars*, religion also has a dark side.¹⁰ You can use it to send people off on violent crusades, as the Catholic Church did throughout the 11th–13th centuries.¹¹ You can use it to justify torture, as they did in the 16th and 17th centuries when Catholics and Protestants tortured and burned one another across Europe in fights over words on a page.¹² In colonial New England, Puritans hanged nineteen of their neighbours as witches in 1692.¹³ Buddhist monks blessed Sri Lankan soldiers in the civil war, and in Myanmar Buddhist nationalism fuelled the expulsion of the Rohingya.¹⁴ In India, religious nationalism has preceded waves of communal violence from 1947 to the present.¹⁵ And at Jonestown in 1978, a single charismatic preacher, Jim Jones of the People's Temple persuaded (and forced) over 900 people to drink what many of them knew was poison, some of them killing their own children in the process.¹⁶ You can reject religion if you want. You can pretend it is a dumb relic of a more primitive past, as too many scholars have done. But its powerful influence remains.

So, we ask the question “What is religion?”

7 C. Schumann and T. Ziegler, “The Contribution of Faith-Based Health Organisations to Public Health,” *British Journal of General Practice* 61, no. 590 (2011): 534–35.

8 Bernard Appiah, “Handle with (Faith-Based) Care,” *CMAJ: Canadian Medical Association Journal* 185, no. 5 (March 19, 2013): E219–20, doi:10.1503/cmaj.109-4393.

9 David J. Garrow, *Bearing the Cross: Martin Luther King, Jr., and the Southern Christian Leadership Conference* (New York: William Morrow, 1986).

10 Mark Juergensmeyer, *Terror in the Mind of God: The Global Rise of Religious Violence*, ed. 4 (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2017).

11 Thomas Asbridge, *The Crusades: The War for the Holy Land* (New York: Ecco, 2010).

12 Cullen Murphy, *God's Jury: The Inquisition of The Modern World* (Houghton Miffling Harcourt, 2012); Toby Green, *Inquisition: The Reign of Fear* (Pan Books, 2008).

13 Mary Beth Norton, *In the Devil's Snare: The Salem Witchcraft Crisis of 1692* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 2002).

14 Stanley J. Tambiah, *Buddhism Betrayed? Religion, Politics, and Violence in Sri Lanka* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992).

15 Ashutosh Varshney, *Ethnic Conflict and Civic Life: Hindus and Muslims in India* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002).

16 Rebecca Moore, *Understanding Jonestown and Peoples Temple* (Santa Barbara: Praeger, 2009).

Unfortunately, this is not an easy question to answer. Many people have tried to pin it down, but the vast majority have failed. It is a major problem openly acknowledged by scholars in the field.¹⁷ Belzen, for example, states plainly that “generations of scholars have failed to achieve a consensus on how to define it.”¹⁸ As Molendijk notes, already by 1901 scholars could identify 48 definitions of religion!¹⁹ “In social sciences, there is no consensus...”²⁰ In the legal context, “no consensus....”²¹ In Religious studies, no consensus.²²

No consensus. No consensus. No consensus.

I would argue it is more than mere of consensus. I see a sea of confusion. I am using AI (Kimi.AI) to do a rough collation of all definitions that exist. We are currently at 68 and counting.²³

Why?

Maybe it is because everybody is confused. Maybe everybody who studies religion provides their own definition because nobody can agree completely on what anybody else has said.

Still, I'd like to give it a go. I want to start with the absolute basic fact about religion which is that it is an institution created by human beings. What is an institution? Here I will offer my own straightforward definition which amounts to a synthesis of several others.²⁴ An institution is basically a set of norms, rules,

17 J. G. Platvoet and A. L. Molendijk, eds., *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts and Contests* (Leiden: Brill, 1999).

18 Jacob A. Belzen, “Paradoxes: An Essay on the Object of the Psychology of Religion,” in *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts, and Contests*, ed. J. G. Platvoet and A. L. Molendijk (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 93.

19 Arie L. Molendijk, “In Defence of Pragmatism,” in *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts and Contests*, ed. Jan G. Platvoet and Arie L. Molendijk, vol. 84, *Studies in the History of Religions* (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 3–19.

20 Ahmet Erdi Öztürk, “Politics in Religion, Religion in Politics,” *International Journal of Religion* 4, no. 1 (2023): 1, doi:10.33182/ijor.v4i1.2837.

21 Alex Deagon, “Towards a Constitutional Definition of Religion: Challenges and Prospects,” in *Research Handbook on Law and Religion* (Edward Elgar Publishing, 2023), 17–33, doi:10.4337/9781788977807.00011.

22 Ezra Chitando, “A Curse of the Western Heritage? Imagining Religion in an African Context,” *Journal for the Study of Religion* 10, no. 2 (2022): 75–98.

23 Mike Sosteric, “Definitions of Religion,” 2026, <https://repo.lightningpath.org/resources/definitions-of-religion.pdf>.

24 Douglass C. North, *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990); W. Richard Scott, *Institutions and Organizations* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 2001); Elinor Ostrom, *Understanding Institutional Diversity* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2005); Geoffrey M. Hodgson, “What Are Institutions?,” *Journal of Economic Issues* 40, no. 1 (2006): 1–25, doi:10.1080/00213624.2006.11506879.

roles, expectations, incentives, and sanctions that systematically organize human behaviour towards some specific end.

Think about education for a moment. Our society's educational institutions organize human behaviour towards a *pedagogical* (i.e., educational) goal, the goal being an educated workforce. It does this through the norms, rules, expectations, incentives, and sanctions that comprise it. **Norms** are the unwritten social standards, arrive on time, raise your hand, wait your turn, don't interrupt, respect personal space, do neat work, use an indoor voice, etc. **Rules** are the explicit, often written prescriptions and prohibitions, don't plagiarize, no cheating, no phones, mandatory attendance, dress code, no bullying, meet deadlines. **Roles** are the distinct social positions or "parts" that people play, teacher, student, principal, etc. **Expectations** are broader role-based or predictive beliefs about what people should do or what will likely happen. Teachers should prepare lessons and grade fairly, students should study and participate, parents should support attendance, if you study you'll pass, if you graduate you'll get a good job. **Incentives** are the rewards or deterrents that motivate compliance. These include grades, stars, praise, awards, scholarships, graduation, college admission, and also fear of detention or parental disappointment. **Sanctions** are the actual consequences for violation of norms and rules. These include detention, suspension, expulsion, failing grades, loss of credit, and informal sanctions like shame, gossip, ostracism, and exclusion. Together, these norms, rules, roles, expectations, incentives, and sanctions systematically organize how people behave in schools towards an end goal, which is a completed education.

Religion is an institution in the same basic sense. Like all institutions, it has norms, rules, expectations, incentives, and sanctions. Like all institutions, religion is designed to organize (you might say control) human behaviour and aim it at some specific end.

Table One: School and Religion as Institution

Term	What it is	School examples	Religion examples
Norms	Informal, shared standards of behaviour	Arrive on time; raise your hand; wait your turn; don't interrupt; respect personal space; use an indoor voice.	Dress modestly; fast on certain days; remove shoes in sacred space; show deference to elders or clergy.
Rules	Formal, explicit, often written prescriptions or prohibitions.	Don't plagiarize; no cheating; no phones; attendance is mandatory; dress code; no bullying; assignment deadlines.	Dietary laws; Sabbath restrictions; membership requirements; baptism or confession rules; prohibitions on certain marriages or practices.
Roles	The parts that people play	Students, teachers, principal, maintenance staff.	
Expectations	Role-based or predictive beliefs about what someone should do or what will happen.	Teachers should prepare lessons and grade fairly; students should study and participate; parents should support attendance. "If you study, you'll pass."	Clergy should teach and model virtue; parents should raise children in the faith; believers should attend services. "If you sin, you'll be separated from God."
Incentives	Rewards or deterrents that motivate compliance before the fact. Can be formal or informal, positive or negative.	Grades, stars, praise, awards, scholarships, graduation, college admission; fear of detention or parental disappointment.	Salvation, enlightenment, eternal reward, community belonging, status, peace; fear of hell, excommunication, or shame.
Punishments / Sanctions	Actual consequences imposed for violation. Formal or informal.	Detention, suspension, expulsion, failing grade, loss of credit; informal: ostracism, shaming, gossip, exclusion.	Penance, excommunication, shunning, loss of membership, divine or cosmic punishment (purgatory, hell, karma), social exclusion.

We will consider what the end goals of religion might be later. For now let's stay focused on the definition. At this point we can define religion as an institution. As an institution, it is designed to organize human behaviour towards some specific end. This is *prima facie* true. You don't go into all the work of building an institution for random reasons. You do it to organize human behaviour towards some end. Whatever else it might be, religion is at least that, an institution.

Of course, there is a problem with this definition and that problem is, it tells us something, but it doesn't tell us much. It tells us that religion is not a private feeling, not a sunset, not a mood, and not a delusion. It is an organized, human-built thing, like a school or a government. This is worth knowing. But

knowing religion's *genus* doesn't tell us what religion *is*, exactly, because it doesn't tell us how religion differs from all the other institutions out there. And that is the part we actually care about.

To see the problem clearly, consider how biologists define things. Imagine a biologist who defines "bird" as "an animal." Is the statement true? Yes, absolutely. A bird is an animal. A religion is an institution. But is it a definition of bird? Not even close, because worms are animals, whales are animals, and so are you. The statement places the bird in its broad biological class, its *genus*, but it gives us none of the features that make a bird a bird and not a beetle: feathers, wings, a beak, eggs, hollow bones. A proper definition needs two parts. It needs the genus, the nearest broad class the thing belongs to, and it needs the *differentia*, the specific feature or features that distinguish the thing from everything else in its genus. A bird is a **feathered** animal. Now you can separate a bird from every other animal on Earth with a single question: does it have feathers?

Our definition of religion so far gives us the genus, institution, but not the *differentia*. It tells us that religion belongs to the same broad class as schools, banks, families, courts, and hockey leagues, but not what makes it different from a school, a bank, or a hockey franchise. On that question, the definition is silent. And notice there is a second gap: the definition says institutions organize behaviour "towards some specific end," but it doesn't tell us what religion's end *is*. For education, the end is learning. For banks, the end is profit and the movement of money. For religion... the definition doesn't say. Whatever the end (or ends) of religion turns out to be, identifying it is part of the *differentia* we are missing.

So the definitional work is only partially done. We have the genus. We need the *differentia*. This, I would argue, is exactly where the centuries of confusion come from. The 48 definitions Molendijk found by 1901, the 68 and counting in my own files, all of them are rival attempts to supply the *differentia*. Everyone is mostly agreed on the genus. The fight is over what distinguishes religion from every other institution humans have built. We turn our attention to that battle in the rest of this book.

A note on sources: This book cites two kinds of material. Scholarly citations, books, journal articles, and primary documents support factual and theoretical claims. You will also see occasional references to SpiritWiki, an open online encyclopedia associated with this text. These links are grounded in scholarly citations, but they are not offered as evidence for claims (though you might find evidence in the citations they include). They perform a pedagogical and theoretical function. They represent signposts, included so

interested readers can explore a concept, example, or debate in more depth. They provide me with a tool that I can use to structure and explore theoretical frames. When a SpiritWiki page appears in a citation, read it as an invitation to dig further, to reflect and even theorize, not as the basis for a claim.

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